

PINK FLOYD THE WALL

**PINK FLOYD'S ORIGINAL CONCERT PRODUCTION OF THE WALL
IN 1980 WAS A MILESTONE IN ROCK HISTORY.
WITH A HOST OF EXCLUSIVE INTERVIEWS AND MANY
PREVIOUSLY UNPUBLISHED PHOTOGRAPHS BY MARK FISHER,
TPI EDITOR MARK CUNNINGHAM RE-DISCOVERS ITS CREATION,
BRICK BY BRICK.**

PINK FLOYD THE WALL



“I always knew it would be a multi-faceted project — a record, followed by shows in just a few cities, and then a movie...” ROGER WATERS

Theatrical rock'n'roll is a commonplace beast in the 21st century. Quite often, even mediocre talent is transformed into something superhuman with the aid of impressive set architecture and video screen enhancement. It wasn't always like this.

In the mid-1970s, artists like David Bowie and Alice Cooper, though their respective *Ziggy Stardust* and *Welcome To My Nightmare* tours, added special props and set pieces to contrive a theatrical flavour that was unusual for a live rock show. However, multimedia rock theatre took several mammoth leaps forward when, in 1980, Pink Floyd transferred their new double album *The Wall* to the stage for the first time and produced a truly multimedia production that more than a quarter of a century later is still regarded as a highlight in rock concert history.

Written by the band's bassist and foremost songwriter of that period, Roger Waters, *The Wall* was a story of alienation and withdrawal, largely fuelled by his experience of touring the *Animals* album in North American stadiums during 1977.



Whilst on the road, Waters had reported his frustration at the “meaningless ritual” of live performance, where his intensely personal songs were treated with a lack of respect by “whistling, shouting and screaming” audiences. In Montreal, at the end of the tour, he took it out on an innocent fan in the front row by spitting in his face.

“By that time, we were playing in stadiums to enormous numbers of people, most of whom couldn't see or hear anything,” says Waters. “A lot of people were there just because it was the thing to do. They were having their own little shows all over the place, letting off fireworks and beating each other up. As the tour went on, I felt more and more alienated from the people we were supposed to be entertaining.”

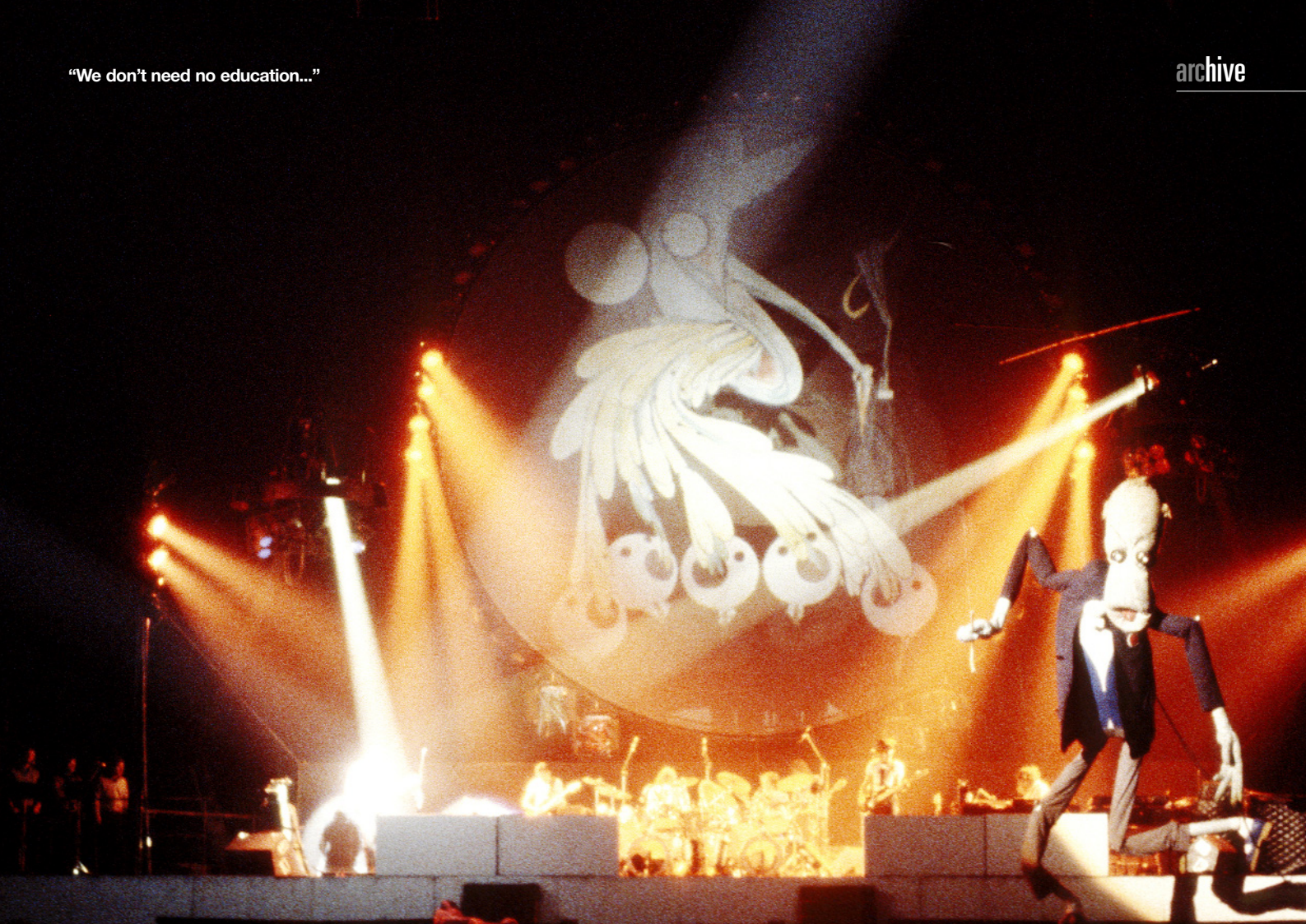
Stadium rock had become such an isolating experience that he imagined building a wall between the band and its audience. Now, there was an idea...

In Waters' mind, *The Wall* was never going to be just another Floyd album followed by yet another tour. He says: “I always knew it would be a multi-faceted project — a record, followed by shows in just a few

cities, and then a movie [directed by Alan Parker]. It couldn't possibly travel because of the sheer expense of getting this thing to move. It was miles ahead of anything that had been done in rock'n'roll and the amount of effort that went into every single detail was unheard of. It was very f***ing difficult to do but we had some very good people on board who made it happen.”

Recording sessions for *The Wall* began in 1978 at the band's own Britannia Row Studios in north London but moved to Superbear in France and then Los Angeles and New York when they were forced to spend a year in tax exile. During the sessions, Waters' concept for a live show started to take place and he would often break off to discuss design ideas with set designer Mark Fisher and Sunday Times cartoonist and illustrator Gerald Scarfe, both of whom had worked with the Floyd for several years.

Conversations also extended to promoter Harvey Goldsmith who was consulted on the practicalities of staging the shows. “Roger took me out for dinner one night and said, ‘I've got this idea’, and he started to tell me about this story. He said, ‘As the show progresses,



this wall will build up and up and up...'. We talked it through and he pretty well had the whole show in his mind. It marked a big turning point in the history of live shows."

Robbie Williams, who had been part of the Floyd entourage since 1972 and was the band's sound crew chief at the time of *The Wall*, says: "Most of us assumed that these concerts would just involve a slightly bigger PA system and a few lasers. I don't think anybody had any conception of what was going on in Roger's mind, and when we first heard that he wanted to build a this wall with the band performing behind it, we all said, 'You've got to be f**king mad!'. We thought the audience would storm the stage and that the poor guys at front of house were going to get killed. Fortunately, it didn't turn out that way!"

As well as a number of massive inflatable puppets based on Gerald Scarfe's distinctive *Wall* cartoon sketches of the Teacher, the Mother, and Girlfriend/Wife, the central 'prop' was the wall itself. As

early as December '78, Mark Fisher sent a dozen examples of "genuine Britro brand kiddie bricks" to Graeme Fleming, Britannia Row's head of lighting and the man who would become production manager on the *Wall* shows when they went into production. A covering note explained that "although a bit of care may be necessary to assemble them, they do form an elegant executive paperweight... when completed and interlocked".

Containing 420 white, cardboard bricks, and measuring 31 feet high by 160 feet wide, the wall was slowly constructed in front of the band during the first 45 minutes of the show by a six-man team from the Britannia Row crew — a.k.a. the Britro Brick Company — until Waters slotted the final brick into place at the end of 'Goodbye Cruel World' to signify the intermission. The show climaxed with the collapse of the wall against a volley of explosive sound effects and smoke. Under such circumstances, a traditional encore would have been a trivial irrelevance. Instead, the

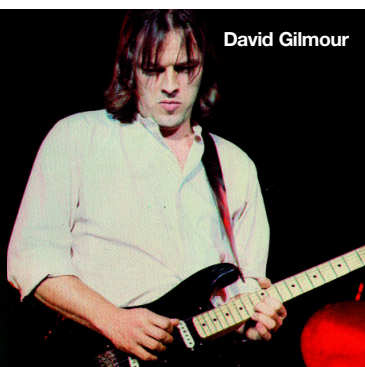
audience was greeted by the final song, 'Outside The Wall', performed by the entire cast (with Waters and Gilmour unusually on clarinet and mandolin) in front of the remains of the wall.

PERSUASION

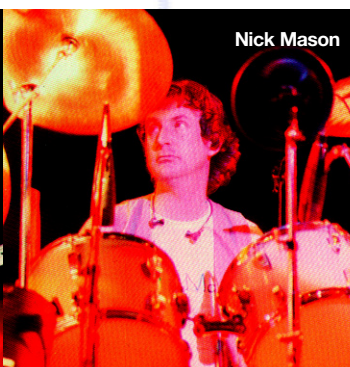
Fisher credits Graeme Fleming as the main influence for making the shows happen in the first place. "Graeme was very instrumental, It actually took a lot of effort to persuade the band and Steve O'Rourke [Floyd's manager] that the show could be done at all," he says.



Roger Waters



David Gilmour



Nick Mason



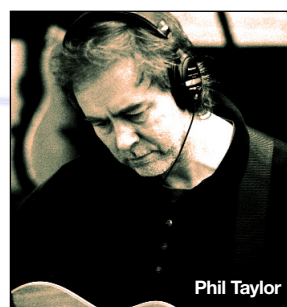
Richard Wright



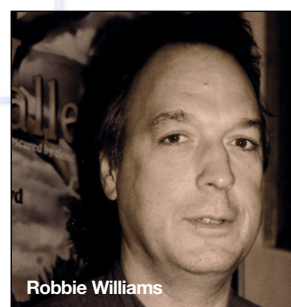
Mark Fisher



Jonathan Park and Graeme Fleming at Culver City Studios



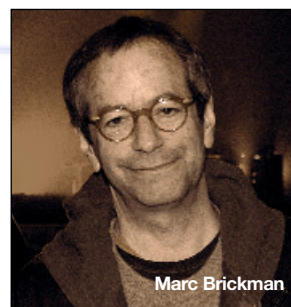
Phil Taylor



Robbie Williams



James Guthrie



Marc Brickman



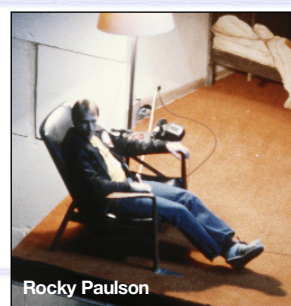
Mick Treadwell and Andy Shields



Mark Fisher and Gerald Scarfe negotiate with Mother



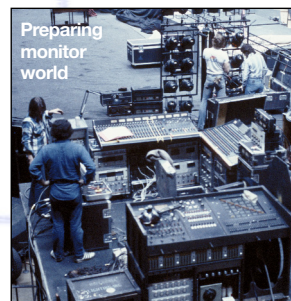
Greg Walsh and Rick Hart



Rocky Paulson



The first load-in



Preparing monitor world

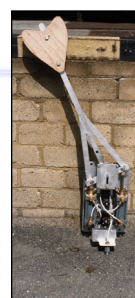
"The possibility of the show had been discussed ever since the end of the 1977 tour. In the winter of 1978-79, I made a series of drawings showing how the technical process of building the wall might work, and how the bricks might be transported and assembled — because of the huge volume required to build the wall, it was essential that they could pack flat. Around this time, the project was heavily side-tracked by Steve O'Rourke's idea of touring the show with its own venue, which was to be a giant inflatable slug. I made a number of studies of the building, along with the show. By late spring, reality prevailed, the slug was abandoned, and the band agreed that if live shows

based on the album were to be done at all, they would be performed in arenas.

"But there was a lot of skepticism about the feasibility of building up a wall during the show, and then knocking it down at the end, which was what Roger's vision demanded. Roger, of course, was very keen on building the physical wall rather than relying on animation to tell the story. But plenty of other people thought it would be impossible (or impossibly expensive) and advocated a more conventional Floyd show in which the building and demolition of a metaphorical wall would be portrayed on the signature circular screen.

"In the early summer of '79, Graeme and I researched the practical side of building and touring a physical wall and came up with some numbers. The numbers were, of course, hopelessly unrealistic. But Graeme became a booster for the project, and in the end it was he who put his neck on the line and persuaded the band to go ahead with the project."

Concurrently, Gerald Scarfe worked on the show animation of the metaphorical wall, and on the main characters which Waters decided he wanted to be represented by inflatables. Fisher explains: "I met with Gerald and in the early summer I sculpted a maquette for an inflatable character and sewed up the full-size



Above: Test-building the wall outside Brit Row's Brentford warehouse; Graeme Fleming, Mark Fisher, Ricky Newton, Andy Shields and Les Squires line-up with the prototype bricks; the 'elbow' device... and an early wall collapse test; Jonathan Park at Genie Industries testing the prototype 6m long x 9m high loading bridge platform.



The Mother inflatable



The Teacher



The Girlfriend/Wife



The Pig

head. The band were recording the album at Superbear Studios outside Nice at this time. Graeme and I stuffed the inflatable head in a hamper, gathered up the drawings, and headed to the south of France for a final sign-off meeting in September 1979."

With Scarfe's approval, Fisher and assistant Sue Donaldson sewed the fabric for the eventual inflatable puppets of the Teacher, Girlfriend/Wife and Mother in a back room at Britannia Row's warehouse. A larger and more animated version of the Teacher, using microprocessor activated electric motors, was later built by Rob Harries at Air Artists for the original film version of *The Wall*, directed by Michael Seresin. Although briefly filmed, the footage was never used in the final 1982 Alan Parker-directed movie. Harries also fabricated a new version of the Floyd pig. These were all rigged by Rocky Paulson, who had previously been the rigger for the North American leg of the *Animals* tour.

After the successful meeting in France, Fisher and Fleming returned to London and one of the latter's first moves was to hire Jonathan Park as the project engineer. Fisher continues: "The project had always divided into three distinct parts: the design of the bricks, the process of building the wall, and knocking it down. In my first sketches I proposed using triple Genie lifts rolling on tracks to raise the men and bricks up to the top of the wall, which was to be 12m tall and 70m wide when completed. Jonathan developed the

Genie idea into a safer and more efficient system of five 6m long bridges that spanned the 30m wide centre-stage preset opening in the wall. In the process, he invented two new products for Genie that have become industry standards — the double lift containing two telescoping masts mounted back-to-back, and the platform lift.

"To develop the design and supervise the construction, Jonathan worked out of Genie Industries' factory in Seattle. Through the autumn and early winter of 1979, he commuted between London and Seattle, which was not much fun under Graeme's rigorous travel regime. Back then we all flew stand-by economy, which meant turning up at the TWA office in Victoria at 05:00 to wait in line for tickets before heading to Heathrow to catch the flight.

"Jonathan developed his bridge system so that when it was assembled the bases became an integral part of the stage, with the bridge decks flush to the stage decks. The bridges elevated to 7m above the stage, allowing crew to place the top row of bricks."

The design of the bricks went through a number of changes, starting with a slot-together Styrofoam design, and ending up with a flat-fold brick made from fireproof dual-wall corrugated cardboard. The final

brick design was 1.5m long, 0.75m high, 0.3m deep, and weighed 11kg. To fill the gap during the first half of the show, over 300 bricks were placed during the 30 minutes of wall building.

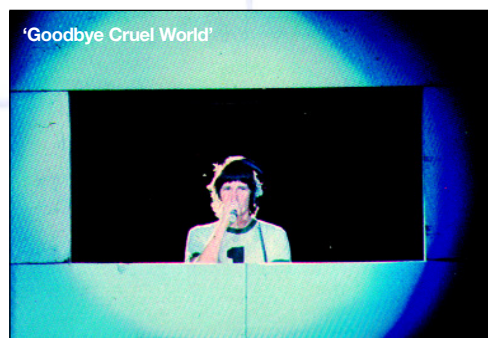
Says Fisher: "When the wall was complete it stood 9m above the stage and was very slender for its height. Therefore, to prevent it from toppling over, it was stabilised by telescoping masts set at 3m intervals across the stage. The brick boxes were open at the top and bottom, and the masts rose up inside the boxes to stabilise them. The telescoping masts were integrated into the base structure that supported the bridges. Jonathan designed a very elegant device that attached to the top of each mast to solve the third part of the puzzle — how to knock the wall down without wiping out the front rows of the audience.

"When a simple wall falls over, it breaks at a point about one third of its height above the ground. The top two thirds of the wall tip over as a flat slab, and then fall downwards and away from the base. Left to itself, a wall rising 12m from the arena floor would require a safe area of 15m downstage of it to protect the audience from harm, however, no promoter would have accepted the loss of seats that would be 'killed' by such a wide safety zone.

"The device that Jonathan designed was a knocker (we called it the 'elbow') that elbowed the bricks off



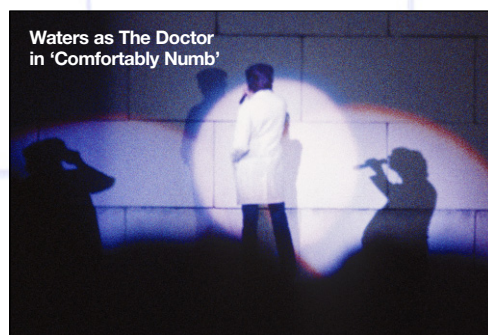
The expanded audio mix position at front of house



'Goodbye Cruel World'



'Is There Anybody Out There?'

Waters as The Doctor
in 'Comfortably Numb'A crew-eye view of Gilmour as he performs his
magnificent 'Comfortably Numb' guitar solos

the top of the wall, row by row, as the telescoping mast was retracted. The elbow could knock the bricks either upstage or downstage. Thus the number of bricks falling downstage could be controlled, and they all fell very close to the base of the wall. In the end, we allowed a safety zone of just 10ft between the face of the wall and the front row of seats."

The original lighting and pyro effects design came from Fleming who specified an overhead lighting truss fitted with PAR cans and ACLs (the advent of the 'intelligent' moving light was a year away), the circular 'Mr. Screen' with perimeter lights and a further two hydraulically-moveable rigs on cherry pickers containing PAR 38s, pin spotlights and manual follow spots. There were also several floor cans pointing up at band members. When the band reappeared from behind the wall in the second half, a further pair of trusses and manned spot positions were revealed, containing more than 200 PARs.

As the pressure mounted in the final weeks running up to the opening show, Fleming's dual role as production manager and lighting designer grew from a challenge into a logistical nightmare. By the time the entourage gathered at the Los Angeles Sports Arena to load-in, it became clear that it was impossible for Fleming to deliver on two full-time jobs simultaneously and O'Rourke invited LD Marc Brickman (who had impressed with his recent Springsteen work) to take a look with a view to him relieving some of the pressure. The following 18 hours saw Brickman continuously play the album until he had re-mapped the lighting scheme, re-cueing and re-gelling as he saw fit, with the on-site assistance of head electrician Mick Treadwell.

Brickman, who has remained a Floyd associate ever since, says: "They can do *Tommy* on Broadway and call it a rock opera, but Roger's piece is the ultimate theatrical piece ever in rock'n'roll, and I was really fortunate to be a part of that. No one will ever top it."



IN THE FLESH

Pink Floyd held the live premiere of *The Wall* at L.A. Sports Arena on February 7 1980, then moved to Nassau Coliseum in New York for five shows, before crossing the Atlantic later that year for six consecutive sold-out nights at London's Earls Court on August 4-9.

Few bands had dared to even think of staging such an ambitious show. Inevitably, *The Wall* grew into a logistical nightmare that required setting up specialist teams within the crew to ensure precision — a commonplace procedure today.

The complex music also determined that each Floyd member was duplicated a 'surrogate' band (Andy Bown, Snowy White, Willie Wilson and Peter Wood) and enhanced by four backing vocalists (Jim Haas, Joe Chemay, Jon Joyce and Stan Farber). It was also Waters' idea that the Floyd members would each have a 'shadow' and this was reflected in the positioning and lighting of the musicians. It was Brickman's idea to uplight the Surrogate Band and project their shadows on to the wall in the 'In The Flesh' reprise to make them appear ghostly.

Waters' vision necessitated two custom-built stages, one in front of the other at slightly different heights, which were separated by a large, black Duvetyne drape. The task of placing the building of the wall between the two stages and isolating the band from the audience while the show was in motion was no mean feat in itself. Add to this the operation of the Scarfe inflatables, the flying pig and crashing Styrofoam model Stuka (built by Don Jose),

Fleming and Brickman's imaginative lighting, film projections, and copious pyrotechnics, and one begins to appreciate the intensity that built up behind the scenes while the audiences sat there agog.

All senses were sent reeling from the very beginning of the show, which began with a quite startling piece of deception. Despite being introduced as Pink Floyd by a deliberately tacky MC, the first number, 'In The Flesh?', was performed at the front of the stage by the 'surrogate' four-piece who wore perfectly formed latex Floyd masks modelled for by the genuine band at the Hollywood film studios during rehearsals.

Bass guitarist Andy Bown — who was taking a break from his regular job as Status Quo's keyboard player — recalls: "I'll never forget the looks on the faces of the people on the front row when we finished that first number with our masks on, and then stepped back as the real Floyd members came forward... like they'd been totally conned!"

'Surrogate' guitarist Snowy White's role was made all the more difficult by his commitments with Thin Lizzy. He says: "It was a crazy period where I was learning two bands' material, which were totally different to each other, all at once. Floyd were rehearsing at L.A. Sports Arena, and every morning in my apartment, I would spend a couple of hours going through Lizzy songs, then polish up on the Floyd stuff before going to rehearse. It was a very busy time!"

The presence of the Surrogate Band meant that on-stage devices instantly multiplied, as crew chief Phil Taylor explains: "I was with the band while they were recording in America, and had to work out how many pedalboards I needed for the show. I

ended up with 11, and because there were no faxes back then, I had to send drawings to Pete Cornish [famed custom equipment designer] by express mail and discuss them with him on the phone.

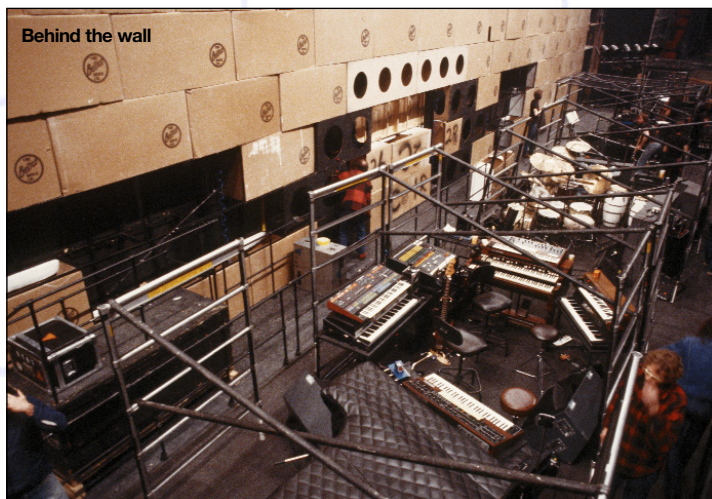
"We were not only adding a second guitarist — we also now had a second bass player who needed his own board, plus we had a complete second stage to equip and I needed another four mini pedalboards for this. I already had some spare send and return units to cover unseen eventualities. I put it all together by working out with David and Roger exactly which effects would be needed for the songs performed on each stage, and then making the boards as compact as possible by including only the necessary effects for each situation.

"Getting all those made when we were thousands of miles away from Pete was a bit of a headache, but he is someone who can always be relied on to deliver the goods."

AT FRONT OF HOUSE

In deciding upon the most suitable FOH sound engineer, the bass player had only one person in mind, and the album's co-producer and engineer, James Guthrie, was approached by Waters several times on the subject. Guthrie, who began his studio career at Mayfair Studios in 1973, says: "I was quite opposed to the idea initially and told him, 'Look Roger, this is a whole different area of expertise. You should get someone more suited to the job, because I have only ever worked in studios.'

"As time went on, the project became more and more complex. Gerald Scarfe had already begun working on the animation which was used for both the film and live shows, as well as graphics. While we were recording in France, Roger cornered me yet again and quite abruptly said, 'You are the only person qualified to mix the live show, so you have to



do it.' He was also enticing me by saying that we could get any piece of equipment we wanted, and being as I'd always liked a challenge, the prospect became more exciting by the day. I finally agreed, and in the end, we had more equipment at front of house than most of today's studios."

Along with the excitement of making this challenge work, Guthrie was quite naturally anxious at the prospect of working in the radically different acoustic environment of the concert arena, although the pressure was lifted by the luxury of spending up to three weeks in production rehearsals at L.A. Sports Arena. This followed preliminary run-throughs of the music with the band at Leeds Rehearsal Studios on Sunset Boulevard (next door to where Jackson Browne was rehearsing), while the set was assembled and tested on a movie sound stage at Paramount Studios in Culver City.

"Once the show started to take shape, the production rehearsals had to take place in the arena simply because the show was so enormous," says Guthrie. "I quickly became acquainted with the acoustics of a large room, albeit an empty one which is another issue altogether. You can EQ and voice the PA thoroughly but, of course, when the doors open and the audience pours in, the acoustics change dramatically.

"This was particularly evident at Nassau Coliseum, where we played in the depths of winter and many of the fans were wearing thick sheepskin coats, which dampened the sound even further. For me though, as a studio-based engineer, the first show would be the first

time I'd have to deal with this phenomenon."

HOLD IT! HOLD IT!

Even though the band and crew had worked solidly on perfecting the show over the previous weeks, not one complete run-through of the production had been attempted without being punctuated by some form of technical or directional problem. Rehearsals continued in this vein right up until the first night, mostly due to Waters' relentless perfectionism.

It should be noted that the credits for the show

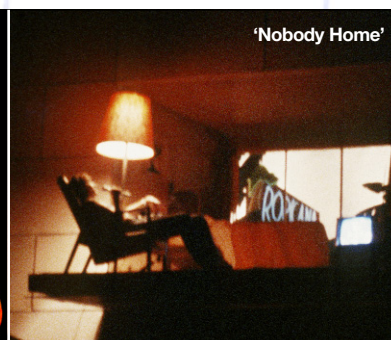
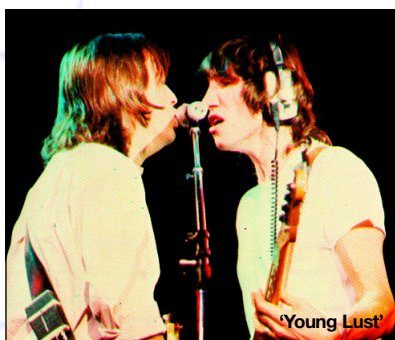
co-ordinate that we would get part of the way through, only to be stopped by Roger's loud voice through the PA saying, 'Hold it, hold it!'. He'd then have a go at somebody for not bringing a puppet out at a vital moment, or saying that the wall should have been built up more by now, and there were also numerous occasions when he'd alert us to badly timed sound effects or lighting cues. It went on and on like this every day with continuous interruptions from Roger, and we were becoming increasingly frustrated ourselves because we were very anxious to do a

complete run-through in order to get a feel for the dynamic and flow of the show."

Despite such wishes, the crew had to contend with rehearsing in sections which, Waters has said, was the only way he could accurately plot the progress of his production. When the big opening night arrived, Guthrie and his front-of-house team joked before the show that whatever occurred, at least Waters could not interrupt the proceedings. After all, this was now playing to a real audience of 11,000 people.

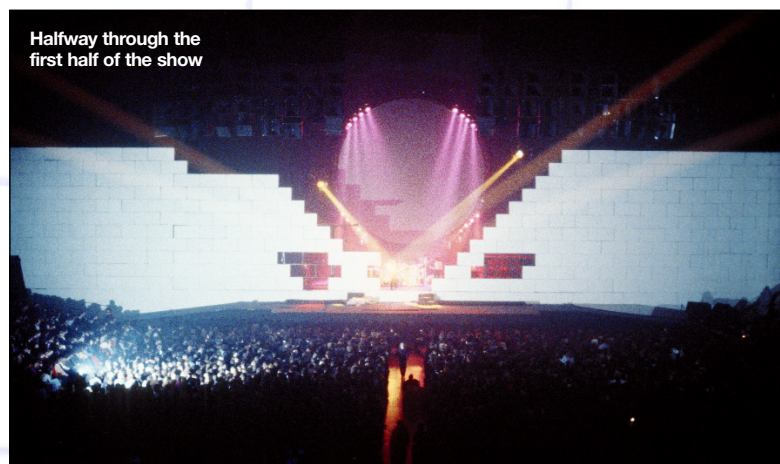
However, as Guthrie explains: "During 'The Thin Ice', I could hear an intermittent electronic crackle. I thought it was coming from one of the drum mics, and my assistant engineers Rick Hart and Greg Walsh were going frantic, listening through headphones and soloing everything in an attempt to find the source of this noise. We couldn't work out what it was.

"Then all of a sudden, Roger shouted through the PA, 'Hold it, hold it!', and I nearly died! I turned to Rick and could see the colour draining from his face. I



read: "The Wall written and directed by Roger Waters. Performed by Pink Floyd." While Gilmour's role was to rehearse the band and ensure that individual parts were reproduced faithfully from the album, Waters' unique position in this whole production arguably made him the only person who knew exactly how the show should be run. Given the additional responsibility as a singer and bassist, his frustration when rehearsed sections did not quite go to plan was hardly surprising.

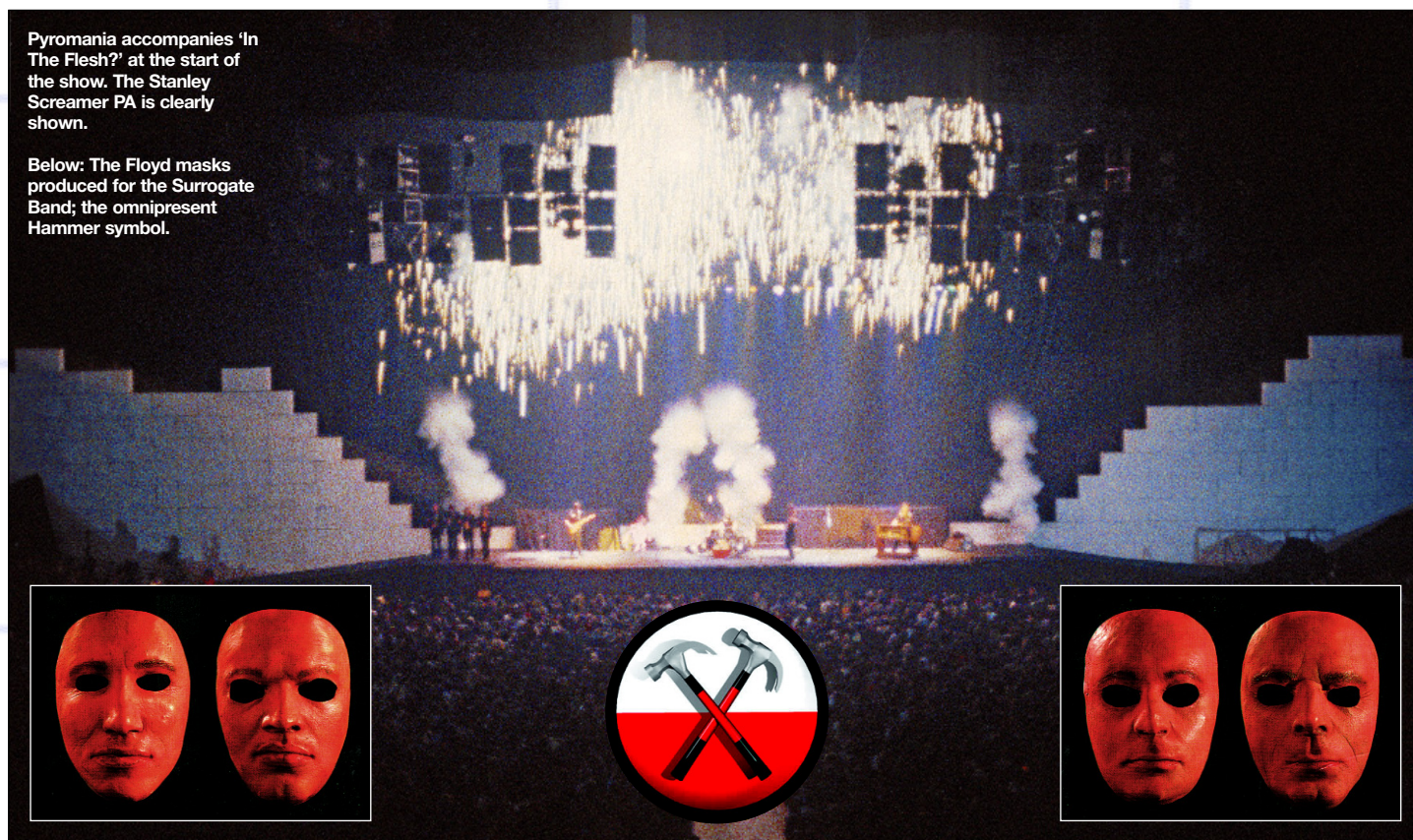
Guthrie recalls: "There were so many things to



The custom-made banner flags hang proud as the completion of the wall signals the intermission

Pyromania accompanies 'In The Flesh?' at the start of the show. The Stanley Screamer PA is clearly shown.

Below: The Floyd masks produced for the Surrogate Band; the omnipresent Hammer symbol.



thought I was dreaming. I looked at Greg, and he had already turned white and was staring in disbelief — I think we were all in shock! The pyrotechnic guys had guaranteed that when the Stuka crashed at the end of 'In The Flesh?', all the flames that accompanied the crash would be out upon landing at the side of the stage. But when they raised the drape between the two stages, some of the embers from the spraying pyros had lodged in the material and caught fire.

"The sound that we'd been hearing had come from the riggers in the catwalks above the stage trying to put out this fire with extinguishers, so it wasn't anything electronic at all!"

Waters remained calm and informed the audience that the show would resume as soon as the minor blaze was under control and the drapes were flown back into the ceiling. Adds Guthrie: "Half the fans panicked and ran to the exits, and the other half were so stoned that they thought it was all a pretty far out part of the act! By the time they restarted the show, I could just about see the stage as the beams of light shone through the heavy, thick smoke left behind."

Vision later improved as the audience was treated

to the heroic sight of Gilmour, hydraulically lifted above the wall to perform 'Comfortably Numb'. According to Phil Taylor, this scene — still my most memorable concert experience — was included in the show at the Waters' express request.

"When we were rehearsing, Roger decided it would be a fantastic idea if David appeared over the top of the wall for his vocal sections and guitar solos," Taylor recalls. He said, 'You should go up on a lift and it'll look great.' I must have been laughing a little too loud, because Roger quickly turned to me and added, 'And you can go up with him!'"

WALL OF SOUND

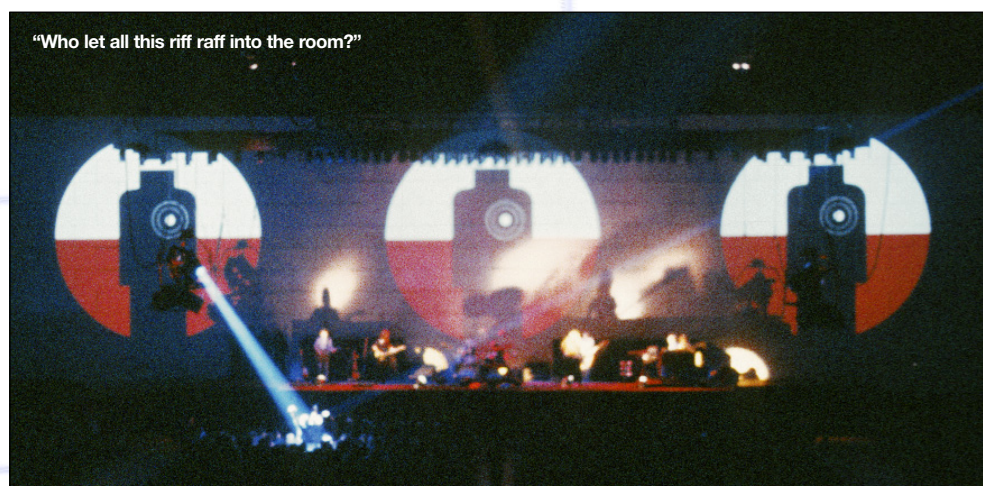
Problems with the opening shows in Los Angeles were not confined to the legendary fire incident. Guthrie's spine tingles at the memory of receiving a whole consignment of defective Altec 15" woofers, which necessitated brisk replacement with Gauss 15" drivers. However, such recollections pale into insignificance when re-appraising what was arguably the most potent PA system of its time.

Purchased by Britannia Row especially for The

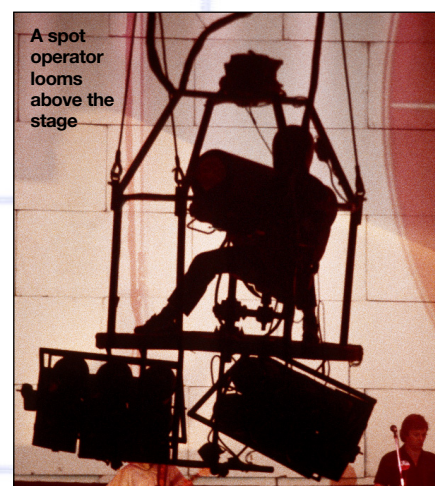
Wall, in addition to a new Martin Quad system, was the new Altec 'Stanley Screamer' — a grid-flown system designed by Stan Miller, which was dubbed 'The Flying Forest' because of its array of different sized constant directivity horns.

Those fortunate to have witnessed any of these magical shows will remember the awesome 'sensurround' experience of having low register vibrations firing up their spine. The influx of sensurround movies in the '70s, such as *Earthquake*, had inspired Guthrie to suggest augmenting the PA with a system which would enhance the show's sound effects.

As well as being placed either side of the stage underneath the PA, a mixture of 16 Gauss-loaded Altec 2 x 18" subs and (in Europe) an unspecified quantity of 2 x 15" Court DLB-1200 cabinets were positioned under seating blocks all the way around the perimeter of the arena. The cabinets were used in conjunction with a sub-sonic synthesizer for ultra low sub-bass at several key points during the show, such as the helicopter buzz on 'The Happiest Days Of Our Lives' and the explosive climax when the wall came tumbling



"Who let all this riff raff into the room?"



A spot operator looms above the stage



Marc Brickman's effective shadow play for 'neo-fascist' reprise of 'In The Flesh'

down.

Guthrie says: "That was when I pushed the fader up as far as it would go, and the whole arena literally started shaking. Anybody lucky enough to have been sitting over those sub-woofers must have been bouncing!"

LAYING THE FOUNDATIONS

No fewer than a massive, and previously unheard of, 106 input channels (not including echo returns) were put under Guthrie's jurisdiction at front of house — remember, these were the days of pure, unautomated analogue mixing. Fortunately, his life was made easier by enlisting the help of assistant engineers Rick Hart, from the album's mixing sessions at Producers' Workshop in L.A., and Greg Walsh.

"There were actually four drum kits, because Nick Mason and Willie Wilson each had a kit on both stages, and we used a colossal amount of microphones. And because Roger and Andy Bown both played bass, there had to be two bass rigs on each stage [two Altec rigs for the front stage and two Phase Linear-amplified Martin rigs at the rear]. So just concentrating on the

balance of the music was enough for me to think about," recalls Guthrie.

At the heart of the mixing process was a very precocious-looking, UV-lit Midas custom console that had debuted in its original form on the previous *Animals* tour. Designed by Midas' key players at the time — Chas Brooke (later of BSS fame), Geoff Beyers and Dave Kilminster — the console consisted of separate mirror-imaged desks, either side of a Midas quad board with joystick panners for each of the quad sub-groups.

Robbie Williams poetically describes this desk package as being "the dog's bits". He adds: "It wasn't the traditional Midas grey either; it was finished in a lovely aubergine colour and really was a splendid piece of kit. By the time we ordered it, we were already operating Brit Row as a rental company, so we had our eyes on the future."

"It looked absolutely stunning," says Chas Brooke. "No one had done that before because it cost a fortune. It included a state-of-the-art op-amp, the Philips TDA 1034, which was a very expensive,

ground-breaking, military specification linear op-amp in a metal case, and we decided that Pink Floyd deserved it for this console. Manufacturing such an elaborate console meant, of course, that it was impossible to make any money out of the exercise, but it was definitely worth the effort."

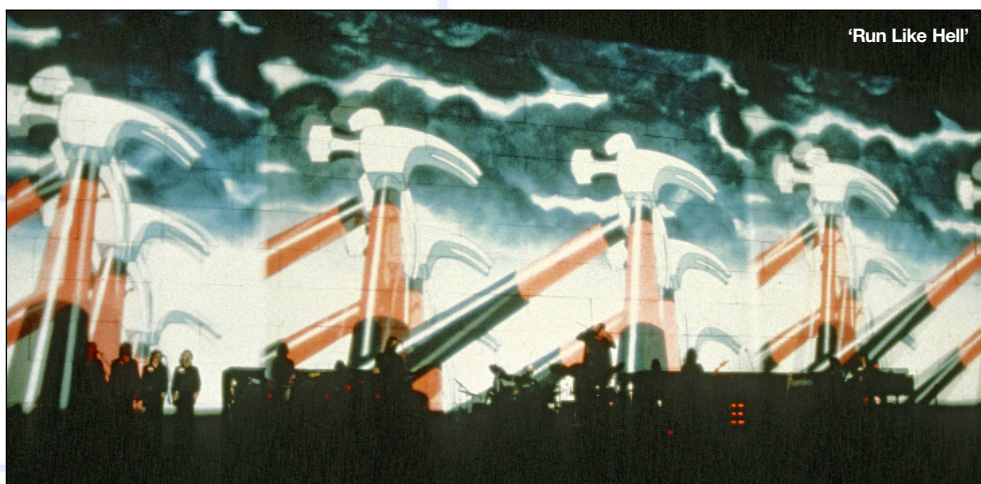
Williams adds: "When it came to doing *The Wall*, however, the demands for channels was such that even with the additional of a 24-channel stretch, we kept patching in extra 10-channel units until we could cope!"

To simplify the complex mix, Guthrie devised a plan whereby Hart would look after the left side of the desk and Walsh, the right, while he mostly concerned himself with sub-groups in the middle. This triumvirate engineering formula was to become a Floyd standard, on later tours such as *The Division Bell*.

"They would feed me whatever was playing at the time. If David was playing acoustic guitar, they would make sure that all of his electric guitar mics were muted, so the only thing being fed was the acoustic. I had a couple of faders that were simply for David's



Waters during 'The Trial'



'Run Like Hell'



guitars and I could balance them accordingly. If I wanted to change the balance between mics, I could just reach over and do that, then return to my normal balancing act. The same regime was followed for the keyboards. Rick Hart was also flying the quad, so when different effects needed to fly around the room, he was operating the joysticks. Greg, meanwhile, was running the echo spins."

A number of outboard units were removed from Britannia Row Studios at Guthrie's specific request. "I just added all the stuff I liked to use in the studio," he says. "We had Urei 1176 and dbx limiters, Eventide harmonizers, Publison DDLs, and for outboard EQ, I used K&H parametrics. In fact, we pretty much emptied Brit Row and stuck everything in touring racks."



This also followed through for the microphone inventory. For drums, Guthrie's choice included an AKG D12 on the kicks, and 202s and 421s on toms, while vocal mics were both Shure M57s and 58s. One of the first quality radio mics, a Nady, was also used by Waters as he wandered the stage for a large proportion of the set.

Guthrie borrowed much from his portfolio of studio techniques for the live shows and began to work on the FOH mix only when he and the band were satisfied with the sound on stage. "It's my standard practice in the studio to get the sound right in the playing area first and then see what I can do to improve on it on the desk, and I was pleased to discover that it also worked well live."

He even voiced the PA in the same way that he

voiced studio monitors, and for this purpose, he carried with him to each venue a Revox and a quarter-inch tape of 'Comfortably Numb' to play through the rig at high levels, while he listened around the arena and ran back to the mixing area to make adjustments on the graphics.

The subtractive EQ techniques for which he had gained a reputation in his studio career were also adopted for the shows. He says: "When you're dealing with PA systems which tend to squawk at you and be a little nasty, it's always a good move to start by cranking up the volume and subtracting what you don't want to hear in terms of frequencies. It always sounds more natural and I can get a much bigger sound that way. You start flat and listen to what is going on, working out if there is a problem with what you have and how you are going to rectify it. One should never EQ for the sake of it, although many people do."

Guthrie's studio experience was further called upon to achieve maximum separation between the backline amplification in a bid to improve control. He and Phil Taylor placed large foam baffles either side of the guitar and bass amplifiers and keyboard Leslies, almost as if they were establishing a studio environment on stage.

Says Guthrie: "We found that underneath the stage was a huge area of low frequency rumbling, which was reducing the definition of the low end, so we hung more of these foam traps down there at varying intervals and it made an enormous difference. The other thing we did was to turn everyone down on stage so the band were playing at an unusually low

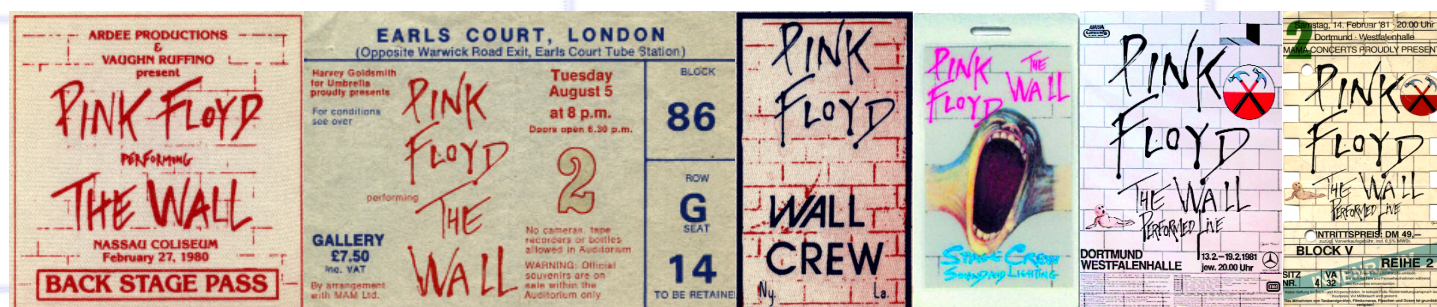
level.

"I thought they would tell me to piss off, quite frankly, but Roger was actually very supportive, because he wanted to achieve the highest resolution sound possible. It was a bit of a problem with David though because, like most guitarists, he needed to play at a certain volume to get the sustain and feedback, so his level would tend to creep up during the show."

Even more control was provided by the ingenious, dual purpose 'hammer' flags which hung above the auditorium at Earls Court, a venue famous for its aircraft hangar-like acoustics. A similar idea had been introduced at the Festhalle in Frankfurt during the Animals tour, where, under Nigel Taylor's direction, the installation of drapes was extremely effective, absorbing the spurious energy which reflected off the venue's walls and domed ceiling. This time, however, these drapes had been transformed into highly memorable visual props.

As Robbie Williams confirms, acoustic consultant Stephen Court, whose Court Acoustics business was then based in the Britannia Row complex, played a part in designing the echo absorption traps for the London shows.

Court says: "Earls Court was a massive lavatory, acoustically-speaking. I had worked with Ken Shearer who had installed the mushroom in the Royal Albert Hall and I'd seen how effective they had been. So between myself and the Floyd crew we had the idea to put up some flags, which in real terms acted as blankets to get rid of all the echo, and the band's artwork team created these wonderful 'hammer' banners."





STAGE MIX

Positioned behind the wall, Seth Goldman ran the extensive monitoring regime with a Midas Pro 2 console for the main stage and another Midas console with Pro 2 and Pro 4 modules for when the band performed on the front stage. All the backing vocals were summed through a small Altec rack-mounted mixer.

What might have sped up the future development of wireless in-ear monitoring was also featured in the show, as Goldman explains: "Kenny Schaffer of Schaffer-Vega built me an ingenious wireless system with Koss 240 headphones for Roger, and he got on with them really well, which probably accounts for why he was one of the first people to take up the original Garwood in-ear monitors when he did his own version of *The Wall* in Berlin in 1990."

Owing to an increase in the amount of monitoring required for this two-stage show, Guthrie states that he was often engaged in an amicable 'battle' with Goldman as he tried to persuade the monitor engineer to reduce on-stage volume. "I was getting quite a bit of monitor spill into the mics, and that's where the potential feedback was coming from. But the stage was very nicely laid out, because the wedges were facing upwards from underneath the stage with a grid on top, so you didn't actually see any wedges from the front of the audience."

ROLL THE SOUND EFFECTS!

The sound effects used live were typically lifted from *The Wall* album masters and remixed to a diamond-shaped Floyd quad format, with the points at left, right, front, and back. Also on tape were a number of instrumental and vocal 'enhancements'.

"The band played everything live," says Guthrie, "but I also played in orchestral tracks, which were remixed into quad for songs like 'Comfortably Numb' and 'The Trial', and for 'Another Brick In The Wall (Part II)' we had all the kids from Islington Green School singing off tape."

"Track 8 carried the timecode, while on track 7, there was a click introduced by a count which we would start in the mixing area and would be heard by

the band either through the room monitors or their headphones. They would then play in time to the animation and recorded tracks which served to enlarge the musical production. This was all done a few years before the advent of samplers, of course."

Adjacent to the sound equipment in the mixing area were three 35mm projectors Mag-linked to two effects-loaded eight-track tape recorders. The Floyd's regular nine metre diameter circular screen was used at the back of the stage for 35mm back projections during the first half, but once the wall was built, it acted as a giant screen for all three of the linked 35mm projectors (manned by Andy Shields) out front for the screening of Gerald Scarfe's stunning animation.

Brit Row's head technician Nigel Taylor routinely battled with the unreliable pre-SMPTE synchronization of the eight-track machines and projectors. "The timecode was on the 35mm mag, and we used Mini Mag synchronizers from a company called Maglink. We had those on the album so we were able to use everything that we'd already recorded," says Guthrie.

Staging the original *Wall* shows allegedly cost Pink Floyd around \$1 million of their own money which, back in 1980, had been unheard of. Steve O'Rourke was once quoted as saying that despite the critical success of the concerts, they actually lost half of their production investment. Ironically, the only Floyd member to have made money from the live adventure was Rick Wright who, having officially left the band at Waters' insistence during the album sessions, was performing as a waged session keyboard player.

One of the best live productions ever executed, *The Wall* was repeated in a final run of

shows the following year in Dortmund and then at Earls Court on June 13-17 1981, from where the best recordings were mixed with those from the 1980 London shows to form *Is There Anybody Out There?* — the double CD souvenir eventually released in 2000.

The 1981 concerts marked the end of what many people consider to be the definitive Pink Floyd line-up, after which their professional relationship — rather like the wall itself — was to collapse in a legal battle between Waters and Gilmour.

Almost a decade later, Waters reprised *The Wall* one more time at Berlin's Potsdamer Platz on July 21 1990 with his Bleeding Hearts Band and an all-star cast featuring The Scorpions, Bryan Adams, Van Morrison, Cyndi Lauper, Thomas Dolby and Sinéad O'Connor. Designed on a vastly more adventurous scale, the Berlin spectacle attracted an estimated audience of around 500,000 and, unlike the Floyd shows to date, it was officially released on video/DVD.

The four members of Pink Floyd would not share the same stage again until *Live 8* beckoned a surprise one-off reconciliation in London's Hyde Park on July 2 2005... the day when pigs really did fly.

TPI





Interviews by Mark Cunningham

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